

PATIENT INFORMATION LEAFLET

1. Study Title & Invitation

Study Title:

A Study Examining the Effect of a Home-Based Walking Program on Fatigue Levels in Breast Cancer Patients Undergoing Chemotherapy

You are being invited to take part in a research study.

Before you decide whether or not to participate, it is important that you understand why the research is being done and what it will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully and discuss it with your family, friends, or healthcare team if you wish. Take time to ask us if there is anything that is not clear or if you would like more information.

2. Why Has This Study Been Designed?

Chemotherapy is a key treatment for breast cancer, but it frequently causes **cancer-related fatigue**—a deep, persistent feeling of physical tiredness and exhaustion that rest does not easily fix.

While staying physically active can help reduce fatigue, attending regular hospital gym sessions during chemotherapy can be difficult due to travel, time, and feeling unwell.

This study has been designed to test whether a structured, simple **home-based walking program** (walking 30 minutes a day, 3 times a week for 12 weeks) helps reduce fatigue compared to standard usual care. By running this study across hospital sites in Ireland, we hope to find an accessible, practical way to support patients' energy levels and overall wellbeing right from their own homes.

3. Why Have I Been Invited?

You have been invited to take part because you meet the specific medical criteria for this study. You may be eligible to participate if you:

- **Are aged 18 years or older.**
- **Have been diagnosed with early-stage breast cancer.**
- **Are currently receiving or about to start chemotherapy** after your initial treatment or surgery (adjuvant chemotherapy).

- **Have been cleared by your hospital medical oncology team** as medically safe to take part in light-to-moderate physical activity.
- **Have been assessed by your treating clinician as having the capacity to understand** this information and make an informed decision.
- **Are receiving your cancer treatment at a participating hospital in Ireland.**

4. Do I Have to Take Part?

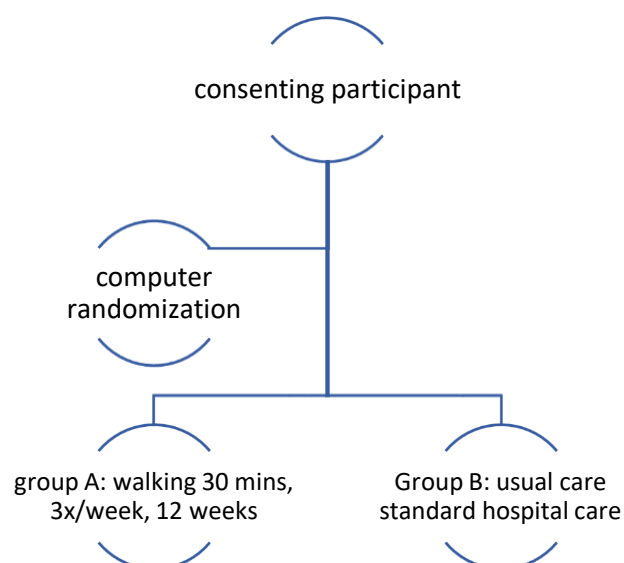
No, taking part is entirely voluntary.

It is completely up to you to decide whether or not to join the study.

- **If you decide not to take part**, your regular medical care, chemotherapy schedule, and relationship with your hospital oncology team will not be affected in any way.
- **If you decide to take part**, you will be asked to sign an Informed Consent Form.
- **If you change your mind later**, you can withdraw from the study at any time without giving a reason. Withdrawing will not affect your standard medical care or legal rights.

5. What Will Happen If I Take Part?

If you agree to participate and are cleared by your clinical team, you will be assigned to one of two groups by chance (similar to flipping a coin or drawing names from a hat). This computer-generated process is called **randomization**, and it ensures the trial gives fair, accurate scientific results.



- **Group A (Home-Based Walking Group):**

You will be asked to follow a simple, structured walking program at home. You will walk for **30 minutes per day, 3 days a week, for 12 weeks** at a comfortable, moderate pace where you can still carry on a conversation. You will be given a simple walking diary and pedometer to log your sessions, and a member of the research team will check in with you by phone periodically to support you.

- **Group B (Usual Care Group):**

You will continue your standard hospital cancer care without adding a structured walking assignment. You are free to continue your normal daily routines and activities as advised by your medical team.

For All Participants:

Regardless of which group you are in, you will be asked to complete a brief questionnaire about your energy and fatigue levels at three time points: before starting (Week 0), midway through (Week 6), and at the end of the program (Week 12). Each questionnaire takes about 10–15 minutes to fill out.

6. What Are the Possible Risks or Side Effects?

Walking is a safe, low-impact exercise, but taking part in any physical activity during chemotherapy carries minor risks. We take every precaution to ensure your safety:

- **Muscle Soreness or Joint Stiffness:** You may experience mild muscle stiffness or leg fatigue when starting out, particularly if you have not been active recently. This usually resolves as your body adjusts.
- **Temporary Tiredness:** Walking should leave you feeling refreshed, not exhausted. If you feel overly tired during a walk, you will be advised to slow down or rest.
- **Risk of Infection and Fever (Low White Blood Cell Counts):** Chemotherapy can lower your white blood cell count (neutropenia), which reduces your body's ability to fight off infections. A fever during chemotherapy is a medical emergency that requires immediate attention.
 1. **Prevention:** We advise walking outdoors in quiet, well-ventilated spaces rather than crowded indoor gyms or shopping centres to minimize exposure to germs.

2. What to do if you feel unwell or have a fever: If your temperature reaches 38°C or higher, or if you experience shivers, chills, or suddenly feel unwell:

- **Do not** exercise.
- **Contact your hospital oncology emergency helpline or go to your nearest Emergency Department IMMEDIATELY.** *Do not wait until the next day, and do not wait to see if your temperature goes down on its own.*
- **Risk of Falls or Strains:** You will be advised to walk on flat, well-lit footpaths, wear supportive footwear, and stop immediately if you feel dizzy, short of breath, or experience chest discomfort.

Safety Contact: A research nurse or doctor will be available throughout the 12 weeks to answer any safety concerns. If you experience unexpected symptoms, you can contact the study team or your hospital helpline immediately.

7. What Are the Possible Benefits?

We cannot guarantee that taking part in this study will directly improve your health. However, potential benefits may include:

- Improved energy levels, reduced fatigue, and better physical fitness during your chemotherapy treatment.
- Extra regular contact and check-ins with the clinical research team.
- The satisfaction of helping us gather scientific evidence that could improve exercise guidance and support for future breast cancer patients in Ireland.

8. What Happens to My Data? (GDPR & Data Protection)

Your privacy is strictly protected by Irish and European law, including the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and the Data Protection Act 2018 (Health Research Regulations).

- **Confidentiality & Coding:** Your name, address, and personal information will be kept strictly confidential. Any data collected about you for the trial will be "coded" (pseudonymized) using a unique participant identification number. Your name will not appear in any reports, publications, or presentations resulting from this research.

- **Storage & Security:** Your paper records will be stored in locked filing cabinets at the hospital site, and electronic data will be saved on encrypted, password-protected hospital server networks.
- **Legal Basis for Processing:** Under GDPR, the legal basis for processing your health data is "scientific research in the public interest."
- **Data Controller:** The Data Controller for this study is [Insert Hospital / University Name].
- **Your Rights:** You have the right to request access to the information we hold about you, request corrections to incorrect data, or restrict how your data is used. If you withdraw from the study, data collected up to the point of your withdrawal will be retained in a coded format to maintain scientific integrity.

9. Will My Taking Part Be Kept Confidential?

Yes, absolutely. All information collected about you during the course of this study will be kept strictly confidential.

- **Pseudonymisation (Coding):** Your name, contact details, and hospital medical record number will be removed and replaced with a unique **Participant Identification Code**. All data collected (such as your questionnaire answers and walking logs) will be stored using this code, not your name.
- **Who will have access to your data?** Only authorized members of the research team will have access to your identifiable information. Authorized auditors, regulatory authorities, or the hospital Ethics Committee may inspect study records to ensure the trial is being run safely and correctly, but they are bound by strict confidentiality rules.
- **Study Results:** The overall findings of this study may be published in medical journals or presented at scientific conferences. You will never be identified individually in any report or publication.

10. What If Something Goes Wrong?

Every effort is made to ensure your safety and well-being during this trial. However, as with any clinical study involving physical activity during chemotherapy, unexpected complications or injuries can occur. Clear safeguards, medical provisions, and formal complaints processes are in place to support you.

What Happens If You Are Harmed During the Trial? (Insurance & Indemnity)

To ensure you are fully protected, compensation and medical care arrangements are divided into two distinct tiers:

- **Medical Treatment for Study-Related Injury (No-Fault / Non-Negligent Harm):**

If you suffer an injury, fall, or health complication that is a direct result of taking part in this walking program, you will receive all necessary medical care and treatment through the hospital system free of charge. This applies even if no one was careless or at fault.

- **Compensation for Negligence (Negligent Harm):**

If you suffer harm or injury as a direct result of negligence or a breach of duty of care by any member of the research team or hospital staff, formal insurance and legal indemnity apply. Indemnity cover is provided by [Insert Institution Name, e.g., University / Hospital / State Claims Agency under the Clinical Indemnity Scheme]. This enables you to make a formal claim for legal compensation.

Note: Taking part in this study does not affect your legal rights to seek compensation under Irish law.

If You Wish to Make a Complaint

If you have a concern, question, or complaint about any aspect of how you have been treated during this study, you have two options:

1. **Speak to the Study Team:** You can raise your concerns directly with the Lead Investigator or Clinical Research Nurse (contact details in Section 12).
2. **Contact an Independent Hospital Body:** If you prefer not to speak to the research team or are unsatisfied with their response, you can submit a formal complaint through the hospital's Patient Advocacy / Complaints Department or through the standard HSE feedback process (*Your Service Your Say*).

11. Who Is Organising and Funding the Study?

- **Organiser / Sponsor:** This study is organized and sponsored by [Insert Institution, e.g., The School of Medicine, University of Galway / Hospital Cancer Directorate].

- **Funding:** This research is funded by [Insert Funder Name, e.g., Health Research Board (HRB) / Irish Cancer Society / Academic Research Fund].
- **Financial Disclosure:** Neither your treating doctor nor the research team receives any personal financial reward or bonus for enrolling you in this study.

12. Contact Details for Questions or Concerns

If you have any questions, require further information, or experience any issues during the study, please feel free to contact any of the team members listed below:

Principal Investigator (Lead Doctor):

- **Name:** [Insert Name]
- **Role:** Lead Investigator / Medical Oncologist
- **Phone:** [Insert Phone Number]
- **Email:** [Insert Email Address]

Clinical Research Nurse / Study Coordinator:

- **Name:** [Insert Name]
- **Phone:** [Insert Direct Line / Mobile]
- **Email:** [Insert Email Address]

24/7 Hospital Emergency / Oncology Helpline:

- **Department:** Acute Oncology Assessment Unit / Oncology Ward
- **Phone:** [Insert 24/7 Urgent Hospital Number]

(Use this number immediately if you develop a fever $\geq 38^{\circ}\text{C}$ or feel acutely unwell).

Data Protection Officer (DPO):

If you have questions regarding how your personal data is handled under GDPR:

- **Name / Office:** Data Protection Office, [Insert Institution Name]
- **Email:** [Insert DPO Email Address]

Independent Contact / Research Ethics Committee:

If you wish to speak to someone independent of the research team about your rights as a participant:

- **Committee:** Clinical Research Ethics Committee, [Insert Hospital / University Name]
- **Email / Phone:** [Insert Ethics Contact Details]